

Council Meeting
May 11, 2019
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The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Saturday, May 11, 2019, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 9:06 a.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew Councilor O'Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Councilor Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Assistant Mayor Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Councilor Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Councilor Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Councilor Koloksi
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Also present:

John MacLean, Interim City Manager
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

CITIZEN'S FORUM

None

BUDGET

Mr. MacLean gave quick recap of the budget letter to the council. He understands that council will have questions. This level funded budget helps keep the tax rate intact. Does not mean council cannot add or subtract. Invest in the community, increases for modest adjustments for staff, need to keep our staff intact. We are a very needy organization, and are very lean in our operations. We have to look at every opportunity to leverage every dollar with grants, capital campaigns and any other opportunities as property taxes will not sustain us.

Mary Walter, verified that council had received the retirement of debt, the CIP approved by Planning Board, and description of the department head extras with descriptions as separate documents. CIP was approved 4/8/19 and should have gone to council after that.

Communications

Chief Chase gave an overview of the department; has 5 full-time – 2 part-time and a communications records manager – completed dispatch wall and center – has been a goal for 25 years. Goal is to become as paper free as possible. He has not asked for any increase in the communication except for union. He stated that one of his biggest concerns was the cost of a new radio system which he said would be close to a million dollars. We are 1 of 2 communities in the state that still has this system and it's built around windows 7. We have been approached from other communities about dispatching for them however he is hesitant to do this with the current equipment. Council asked more questions since the CIP says the cost to replace would be \$350,000. They would like to see the numbers to see what the cost would be to replace it. The city manager felt that this was a deeper discussion than just replacing equipment and we need to look at the bigger picture as there were talks about a regional dispatch center and perhaps, we need to explore everything in a little more depth and come back to the council at a later point.

Department Request \$ 536,531.00

City Manager Proposed \$ 539,891.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the budget for \$539,891.00

Voice Vote: motion carried 9-0

Police

Department Request \$ 2,907,304.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,902,537.00

Chief Chase gave an overview of the police department - 24 sworn officers – Sullivan county's office contracts with them since our prosecutor left. One of the biggest reasons why he left is that he was maxed out and could not see a path to any pay increases. Things have gone smoothly, working with the sheriff's office. Chief also talked about the department's qualifications as a Calea certified department. We were selected as one of seven agencies to test out an online recertification program for Calea. They are coming over the next couple weeks and will be in the community, talking with members in the community. At the June 12th meeting the Police Chief will make presentation about the Celea certification process and what it means to the community.

Improvements done over the past year (or in progress now) – women's locker room just about done, temporary holding cell, cruiser & body camera live, K-9 program.

Prosecutor comes out of the consulting services line item. Current contract goes thru 6/30/19. Attorney General office is seeking a grant to get a victim witness advocate.

All cars are equipped with cameras as are all officers with body cameras. Just went live in the last couple of days. We followed the Celea and federal law about recording and its now part of our operating procedure. The storage is a very robust system thanks to our IT Administrator Chris Burgess and we believe we have enough storage at this point for the next 5 years.

A motion was made by Councilor Pope and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Police budget for \$ 2,902,537.00

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 (Councilor O’Hearne opposed)

Parks

Director Brislin will make the presentation of both Parks & Recreation together and then answer any questions: **The Parks and Recreation Department oversees**

- 10 Parks – Over 500 acres – That Include wide range of facilities such as baseball & softball fields, basketball and tennis courts, playgrounds open spaces and walking trails.
- State of the Art Community Center that averages approximately 8,220 member-check in’s per month, we sell an average of 1,067 day passes per month that totals an average of 9,287 people checking in to use the CSBCC per month. This does not include the many people who are entering the building for many meetings and programs that are held at the CSBCC including youth basketball, swim team and swim lessons.

The CSBCC is open 95.5 hours per week

Monday –Thursday 5:30AM-9PM

Friday 5:30AM – 7PM

Saturday and Sunday 8AM-6PM

Closed on Christmas Day, New Year’s Day, Easter, and Thanksgiving

Limited hours from 5:30AM-1PM on Memorial Day, July 4th, Labor Day, Christmas Eve and New Year’s Eve.

Parks and Programs support economic development by attracting and retaining residents and generating income for the community and local businesses through events that take place throughout the year.

We Run and coordinate a variety of year-round youth and adult sport programs and other recreational activities for all ages. Our...

Youth Sports	1,660 participants
Youth Camps	380 participants
Aquatic Programs	375 participants
Adult Sports	701 participants
Fitness Programming	1,577 participants

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We oversee and coordinate over 15 special events including July 4th, outdoor movie nights, Hallowesta, 5K races, and the egg hunt to name a few.

A few of our major accomplishments over the last year were:

- Replaced and Relocated the playground at Monadnock Park. This not only made the playground more accessible for users but it opened up field space for our growing programs. This project was made possible through the LWCF Grant and the Claremont Savings Bank Foundation Grant.
- Last Fall we replaced and converted all of the lights at the CSBCC to LED lights. This project was to help reduce our electricity cost at the Community Center.
- With continued help and collaboration from CYBSA we were able to add drainage and new infield mix to the softball field at Monadnock Park.
- This Spring we hosted the first Special Olympics regional meet in Claremont. We had over 100 athletes and 70 volunteers participate in these events.

As we continue to grow and develop our programs, we also add wear and tear to our fields and facilities and add increased work load to the existing staff currently made up of one full time and one part time parks maintenance crew.

With the budget we developed and continued support from local businesses we will be able to continue the same level of programming that the community has become accustomed to.

Supplemental Request included

\$27,294 for a part time Maintenance person at the CCBCC.

A part time maintenance person would allow us the opportunity to address many of the needs of the day to day maintenance and wear and tear of the CSBCC and other and other parks and rec facilities.

A part time maintenance person would let us invest in some of the proper trainings for specialized equipment such as the pool and the fitness equipment to properly maintain and perform routine maintenance.

\$59,000 for a new roof on the lodge at Arrowhead

The main lodge located at Arrowhead Recreation Area is overdue for many energy efficient upgrades including replacing the roof, heating system, and exterior windows and doors. The \$59,000 would allow us to install a double layer asphalt shingle roof on the lodge.

\$240,000 to replace tennis courts at Monadnock Park

Monadnock tennis courts require complete replacement and new construction at a cost of approximately \$240,000 to replace and transition the 5-court system to 4 courts. We will need to either restore the courts with a system that withstands the New England climate or eventually close the courts due to the condition and

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reappearing cracks that cause trip hazards and playability issues. This project is a top priority for the Parks and Recreation Department. The Tennis Courts are also used by Stevens High School Tennis team.

In the Extra column – we’ve asked for a part-time maintenance person at the community center and in the Parks budget we’ve asked for \$59,000 for a new roof at Arrowhead lodge as well as \$240,000 for tennis courts at Monadnock park.

There was a discussion regarding the department head request of a part-time maintenance person for the CSB community center and wanted to add that to the budget.

Mr. MacLean thanks the council for this but you have not seen the entire budget.

Mayor Lovett asked if there are any other revenue streams you are looking into. Director Brislin said we have done banners (around ½ of the Gym area).

Department Request \$ 701,503.00

City Manager Proposed \$402,503.00

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to tentatively approve the Parks budget for \$461,503.00 to include \$59,000 roof for Arrowhead.

Mayor Lovett said she is not in favor of adding the money for the roof at this time as she believes we may be getting money in the governor’s budget.

Voice vote: motion failed

A motion was made by Councilor Pope and seconded by Councilor Koloksi to approve 402,503.00 for the Parks budget.

Voice Vote: motion passes 7-2 (Councilor (O’Hearne & Councilor Stone opposed)

CSB Community Center - Recreation

Department Request \$1,131,579.00

City Manager Proposed \$1,105,954.00

A motion was made by Councilor Koloksi and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the CSB Community Center budget for \$1,133,248.00 which includes the extra part time position.

Voice vote: motion carried 6-3 (Councilor O’Hearne, Councilor Stone, Councilor Zullo opposed)

Assessing

Department Request \$355,485.00 City Manager Proposed \$355,485.00

Director Walter explained that we have funded a full time Assessor at the top of the scale, and we have budgeted \$31,000 to do a Vision upgrade as well as money for phase II of the revaluation which will be moving us to a 2-year cycle rather than a five-year cycle. There is also money in the consulting line to cover potential costs of a challenge to utility values done by Mr. Sansoucy. City Manager Maclean explained that he'd read that Sansoucy is being sued by the state and he was the expert we had value our utilities. This could have an impact on us.

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Councilor Zullo to tentatively approve the Assessing budget for \$355,485.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Planning & Development

Director Merrill gave an overview of what this office does. Budget is down due to one-time expenses last year. There is \$25,000 for website upgrade. Very little change from year to year. Rents and leases are not needed as the last payment on the car was made. Pleasant St has \$100,000 in this year's budget to begin design work and \$100,000 was requested for next year to do phase 2 and we will be applying for a federal grant.

Assistant Mayor Damren asked when the new website would be up & running, (we anticipate July).

Department Request \$916,355.00 City Manager Proposed \$916,355.00

A motion was made by Councilor Koloksi and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Planning & Development budget for \$916,355.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Reminder that Tuesday, May 21st will be the Pleasant St meeting at 6:30 p.m. at the CSB Community Center. This will be when the designs and mock-ups of the street will be shown after getting the public's input. All are welcome and encouraged to attend.

TIFD - Downtown

Director Merrill stated that the TIFD Budget is down 9% - about \$80,000
DES says we can close the Brownfields work on the Sawtooth building.

Council asked why the lighting line wasn't down more since we've only used about \$8,000. Ms. Walter stated that electric bills run a couple months behind and there are repairs to the lights that need to be done but she could see it down a couple thousand dollars. If it costs more, we will phase in the additional repairs for another year. She reminded council that these costs are shared with the developers.

Mr. MacLean said the parking garage was built in 2010 and needs to have a primary care provider overseeing it all like DPW. How can we reduce the cost? Stated he is looking at creating a committee made up of city staff. There was some discussion about charging for parking at the parking garage for the 56 public spaces.

Department Request \$783,600.00 City Manager Proposed \$783,600.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Zullo to tentatively approve the TIFD-Downtown budget for \$781,600.00 subtracting \$2,000 from the electric line.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the TIFD-Downtown Revenue in the amount of \$781,600.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Break for lunch at 12:25pm to come back at 1:10 pm.

Welfare

This budget has had no increase and actually has a \$2,000 decrease. Our rent requests have increased – vacancy is .09%, and there's a lack of affordable housing in Claremont. It is very hard to forecast this type of budget. Councilor Pope asked how long has it been since she's had to come back to council for a supplemental budget (about 3 years).

Department Request \$369,765.00 City Manager Proposed \$369,765.00

A motion was made by Councilor Koloksi and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Welfare budget for \$369,765.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Library

Director Grace commended his staff. His extras are the request for return of a position lost in 2018. He is also looking for the return of book money lost in 2018 in the amount of \$10,000

which helps us keep current. Technology & Internet line increase is software maintenance agreement for our new catalog system. The air conditioning has been installed.

Department Request \$480,557.00

City Manager Proposed \$394,322.00

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Councilor Koloksi to tentatively approve the Library budget for \$ 404,322.00 which includes the \$10,000 for the books.

Mr. Grace was asked if there's a group that helps the library raise funds. He said yes, \$5,000-\$6,000 per year is typically raised by the Friends of the Library and it goes to programming

Voice vote: motion failed

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Stone to tentatively approve the Library budget for \$394,322.00

Voice vote: motion passes 7-2 (Councilor Lessard & Councilor Kier opposed)

Fire

Chief Burr stated that not much has changed in this budget; a few line item changes where he's taken from one line to put into another. He said that he does not have all the answers to Councilor Koloski's request for the apparatus replacement plan and he's put in a request to the ISO (Insurance Office) but has not heard back from them yet. (The last rating was done in 2017) Public – there are 433 municipal fire hydrants, x the fee schedule which is \$300.00. City Manager MacLean said there is zero in the managers budget he explained his thoughts and the fact that all of the places contacted do not charge for public hydrants; only private. He said that we would recommend an amendment the ordinance so we no longer make that payment. Hydrants have a dual purpose, firefighting and to flush the system. He did not feel the taxpayers should be subsidizing the utility system. Ms. Walter explained that Unemployment dropped among all budgets as did retirement (saving the city about \$40,000 annually) but workers compensation in the fire department just about doubled.

Department Request \$2,523,893.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,416,317.00

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Fire budget for \$ 2,416,317.00

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 (Councilor Koloski opposed)

Airport

Mr. MacLean said this is a great asset to the city and will be in ADA compliance once the new terminal is done. Chief Burr said have also made improvements at the old Daniels site, this has been cleaned up with the help of DPW and we have changed to LED lighting.

Ms. Lessard asked what will happen when the current volunteers are no longer there, will you have to hire someone. Chief Burr said Mr. Hamel & Mr. Carton have been invaluable assets to the City and he does not have that answer at this time. Chief Burr said we will be updating our Airport Master Plan so this will help us get more data and will help with future grants. Mr. Councilor Koloksi asked if there is a money planned to put into the new hanger? Chief Burr said all our units are filled and there are some requests for hangar space. He believes the next target will be whether we can expand the runways.

Department Request \$112,954.00 City Manager Proposed \$112,954.00

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor O’Hearne to tentatively approve the budget for \$112,954.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Elections

Finance Director Walter stated the budget is down 4% - will have 2 elections this year.

Department Request \$13,683.00 City Manager Proposed \$13,683.00

A motion was made by Councilor Pope and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Elections budget for \$ 13,683.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Debt Retirement (Debt Service)

Finance Director Walter stated this is up \$400.00 even while we are picking up the loan for the lights the community center.

Department Request \$1,170,476.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,170,476.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Debt Retirement budget for \$ 1,170,476.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

City Administration (Finance)

Finance Director Walter gave an overview of the City Admin make up; we have 2 IT staff who handle all the information services for all departments in the city. We also have a ½ time bookkeeper who does all the water sewer billing / shut-offs and is paid for by the water/sewer enterprise funds. We have 3 people in the city clerk/tax collector's office who do all the vital statistics, marriage licenses, death certificates, dog licenses, property tax payments, water/sewer and all other collections as well as motor vehicle registrations, this area brings in 250% of the department budget. We also have 3 people including myself to cover budgets, audits, weekly payroll, daily mail, accounts payable processing, deposits and reconciliation, grants monitoring and all treasury functions. As you can see, we do a lot with limited staff. 12 ½ years is the median of longevity.

Councilor O'Hearne asked about the temporary / seasonal position. Could we get someone part time for more hours? Ms. Walter said that the person would need to be certified in several areas so that's why it's usually someone who's recently retired and still willing to help out. Ms. Melcher said she tries to save the hours for busy times (like when tax bills are due or when she has an election coming up). She said we will feel the pinch when we go to quarterly water/sewer billing. Ms. Melcher will ask if the current person is willing to work more hours. City Manager MacLean appreciates and thanks where Councilor O'Hearne is going. We've certainly felt the pinch here in City Hall in his department with Ms. Russell out, in Welfare with Ms. Watson willing to come over to the manager's office and with Ms. Melcher who has been doing all the minutes.

Department Request \$876,517.00

City Manager Proposed \$876,517.00

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Councilor Zullo to tentatively approve the City Administration budget for \$876,517.00

Voice vote: motion carried 6-3 (Councilor O'Hearne, Councilor Koloski, Councilor Pope opposed)

Municipal Complex (Maintenance)

Finance Director Walter said this department also falls under her and this is difficult as this is a big building with 5 floors in the police section which also houses the Circuit Court system. We have 1 Full time person who has been here over 24 years, and 2 part-time people (1 who left recently due to medical issues). The building needs a lot of major, costly repairs. Last year put in \$100,000 to do the flat roof area of city hall. While trying to develop an RFP, a review done by one expert estimated the cost could be in the area of \$400-\$600K. We do have a contract to do the ADA family restroom. This year's budget includes another \$30,000 for the flat roof repairs because if we can't get it done for that perhaps we can phase it in. The overall budget is down due to the one time increase for capital last year. While we applied for a lot of the upgrades in the LCHIP grant, those weren't funded. We have replaced some of the windows in city hall but there are 50 windows and the cost are about \$2,200 per window.

Department Request \$398,158.00

City Manager Proposed \$398,158.00

A motion was made by Councilor Stone and seconded by Councilor Zullo to tentatively approve the Municipal Complex (Maintenance) budget for \$398,158.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Policy (Executive/HR/Council)

Mr. MacLean said the policy budget is Executive (his and council's) shows the amount for the next city manager. There are 4 full time positions, the executive assistant/ clerk to the council, the office assistant/floater position that was funded at 70% last year, the HR Manager which was also into this budget last year and the city manager. We have increased the amount for the new City Manager so that the council has some flexibility in their request to get the very best person for the job.

Property maintenance has \$15,000 but only \$544.50 spent. Ms. Walter said she has been pulling money from most every line item to pay out the severance pay to Mr. McNutt

Department Request \$644,897.00

City Manager Proposed \$644,897.00

A motion was made by Councilor Kier and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren to tentatively approve the Policy (Executive/HR/Council) budget for \$644,897.00

Voice vote: motion carried 7-2 (Councilor Stone, Councilor O'Hearne opposed)

Outside Agency Request

Mr. MacLean this is the request from Southwestern Community Services for the bus service, they have requested and additional \$5,000 this year and he has put the additional \$5,000 in the extra column. He reminded council that the funds from this come from fund balance.

Department Request \$30,000

City Manager Proposed \$25,000

A motion was made by Councilor Pope and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Outside Agency budget for \$25,000

Councilor Zullo recused himself as he does work for the bus service

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0

General Services

Finance Director Walter said this is all of the shared services for the city. Things like property/liability insurance, legal services, ambulance, auditing, computer equipment for all city departments etc. We have increased legal since the \$95,000 was not enough but we are still under what we were paying for inhouse legal plus outside legal in past budgets. We have cut out the payment for GASB / OPEB liabilities, as it is not required to fund this. Overlay is down, last year we had an abatement with Claremont Savings Bank. We are in the middle of a re-valuation; the Assessor feels confident with the work being done by Vision.

There was some discussion regarding the legal services in regards to having an attorney in house or continue to contract these services.

Mr. MacLean spoke regarding Merit Plan employees, by adjusting the brackets by 2%, we are recognizing they there has been very little compensation.

Department Request \$1,162,357.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,012,029.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the General Services budget for \$1,010,029.00 (which subtracts \$2,000 from the loan to the TIFD)

Voice vote: motion carried 8-1 (Councilor O’Hearne opposed)

Revenue

Finance Director Walter said that we are using \$840,590 from fund balance (\$500,000 of that to reduce the tax rate) and there’s another \$73,500 coming from capital reserves. She also explained that she reduced the line for interest from interest and penalties due to a recent legislative change. Starting April 1 of this year and going forward the interest was dropped from 12% to 8% and, once lienied, the interest rate will drop from 18% to 14%. This is a 33.3% loss of revenue to the city.

Department Request \$5,439,216.00 City Manager Proposed \$5,953,216.00

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Kier to tentatively approve the Revenue budget for \$5,951,216.00

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 3:23 pm a motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Zullo to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0

Respectfully Submitted,

Gwendolyn R. Melcher
City Clerk